PILOT 01 · STORYBOARD V2 · AWAITING APPROVAL

The Claw of Syracuse

This revision answers your notes on the hook, the claw mechanism, the impact, Archimedes and the ending, and the 3D world. Every frame is a still from the real 3D scene. I haven't started the full render, generated any audio or spent any credits.

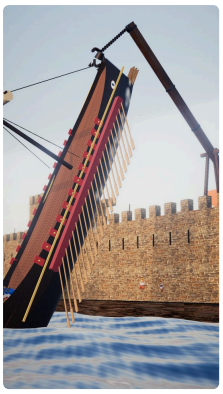
62 s · 22 shots 1080 × 1920 Narration ≈ 177 words

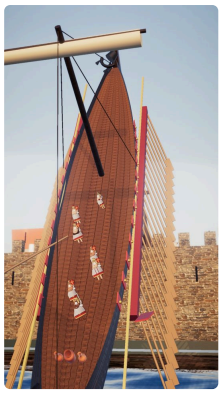
Sources: Polybius 8.3–8.7, Plutarch Marcellus 14–19

WHAT?!	OH NO!	WHOA!
0:00–0:04 · a city wall lifts a warship	0:04–0:37 · night approach, the creak, the claw, the lift, the drop	0:37–1:02 · a 74-year-old mathematician, and Rome ran from his fishing rod

What changed

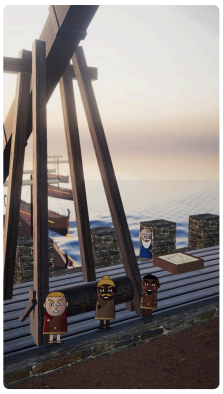
Hook (S01)

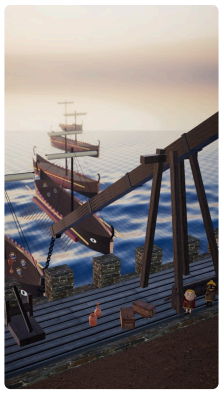

Before


After

Two cuts now instead of one frame: the full scale of a 30 m ship standing on its stern with sailors clinging all the way up, then their faces as they slide toward camera.

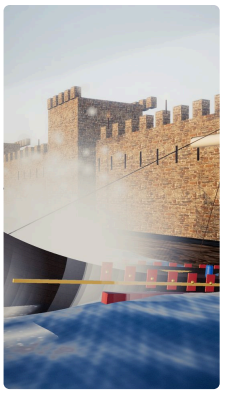
The lever (S09)

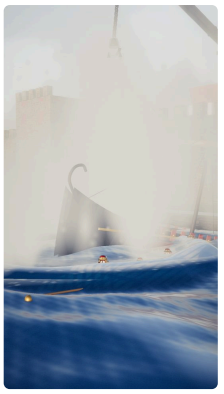

Before


After

Seen from behind and above, the mechanism reads as a seesaw: counterweight end down, beam over the wall, chain to the ship.

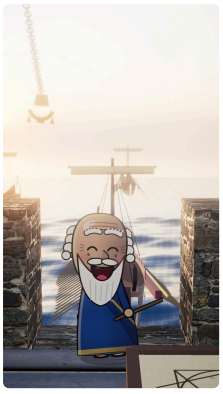
The impact (S14)

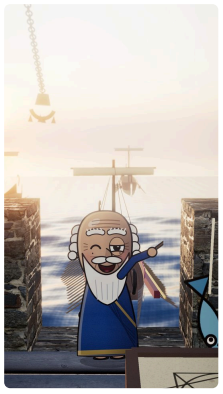

Before


After

Slow motion. A displacement crater and expanding wave ring in the sea surface, a tower of spray, debris splashing. It was a small puff before.

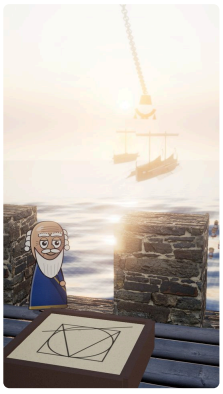
The payoff (S20)

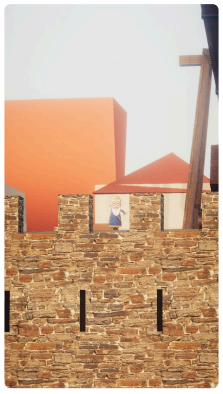

Before


After

The stick is a fishing rod. He lands a fish and winks while Rome's marines flee. It was a generic laugh before.

The ending (S21)


Before


After

Telephoto from the fleet: the wall, the claw at rest and one tiny old man fishing. It was a glare shot before.

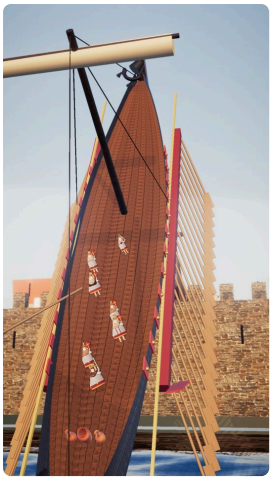
World upgrades across every shot

- The sea surface physically reacts to the impact (crater and expanding wave ring), and floating debris rides the waves.
- Weathered walls with a wet algae line and surf on the rocks. Wall-top catapults, banners, stores, the city of Syracuse behind the wall, distant hills and Etna on the horizon.
- Dawn light that builds through the attack, a low sun glow and a stronger colour grade.
- Falling shields, oars, helmets and amphorae during the lift. Three more crew. A marine leaps overboard in the panic.
- Fixed an anachronism: the deck cargo was a modern plastic drum. It's now terracotta amphorae.

Storyboard

`Documented` stated in an ancient source `Reconstruction` our design, labelled on screen

`Dramatised` plausible staging `Invented` comic beat



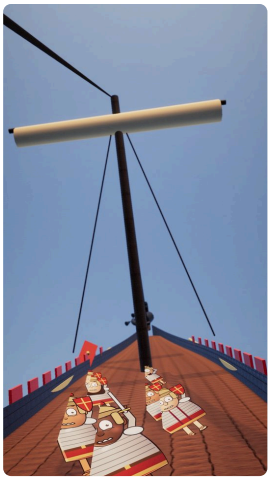
S01a 0:00.0–0:01.9

Hook: a city wall lifts a warship

VO This is a Roman warship...

The whole ship stands on its stern against the wall, chain taut from the beam. Sailors cling all the way up the deck. Water pours off the hull. Chain groans, low drum hit.

Documented Polybius 8.6.3



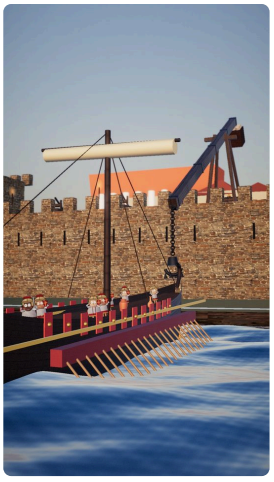
S01b 0:01.9–0:03.6

Hook: the sailors

VO ...and a city wall is picking it up.

Looking up the standing deck: sailors slide toward camera, terrified, amphorae tumbling past.

Dramatised Dramatisation



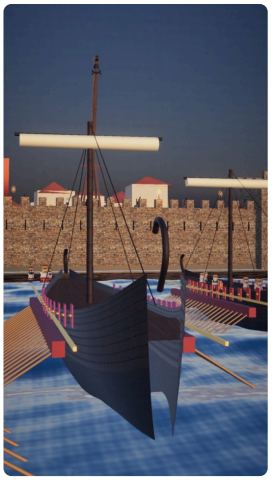
S02 0:03.6–0:04.4

Rewind

VO Rewind.

The world plays backwards: the ship drops and rows out. Rewind whoosh.

Device Storytelling device



S03 0:04.4–0:09.4

Before dawn, the fleet creeps in

VO Syracuse, 213 BC. Before dawn, Rome's fleet creeps toward the city walls.

On-screen text: SYRACUSE · SICILY · 213 BC. Torches, mist, catapults on the wall.

Documented Polybius 8.5.4



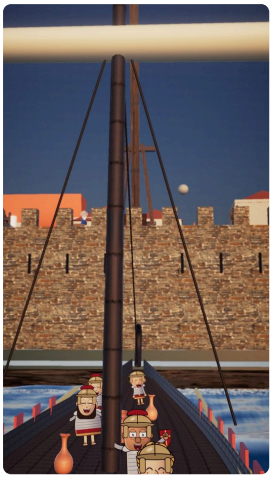
S04 0:09.4–0:11.0

Marcellus' plan

VO The plan: get so close that the city's catapults...

Marcellus whispers, smug.

Documented Plutarch, Marcellus 15.5



S05 0:11.0–0:13.9

Stones fly overhead

VO ...shoot right over their heads. And it works.

Stones whistle over the mast and splash far behind. The crew ducks, then grins.

Documented Polybius 8.5.4–5 (simplified)



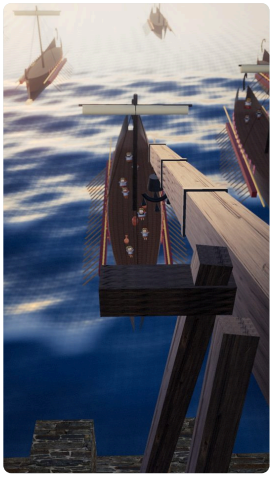
S06 0:13.9–0:16.4

Something creaks

VO Then, above them... something creaks.

Silence. Timber creak. Titus's eyes drift up.

Dramatised Dramatisation



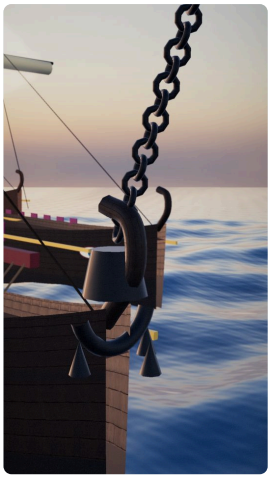
S07 0:16.4–0:20.4

The beam swings out

VO A huge beam swings out over the wall... and lowers an iron hand on a chain.

From the wall top, looking down the beam as it swings out over the ship far below.

Documented Polybius 8.5.8, 8.6.2



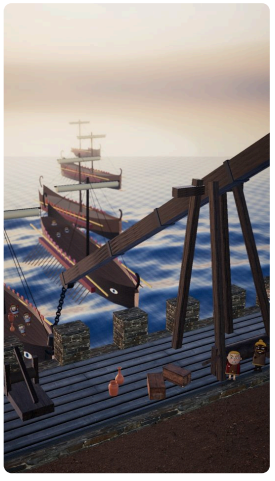
S08 0:20.4–0:22.4

The iron hand bites

VO It grabs the ship by the nose.

Iron on timber. Wood splinters.

Documented Polybius 8.6.2



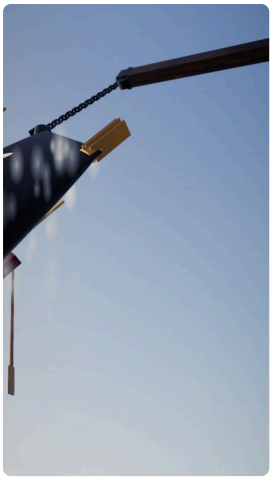
S09 0:22.4–0:25.9

The lever

VO Behind the wall, the far end of the beam is pushed down, like a seesaw...

From behind and above the machine: the counterweight end drops, the crew heave, the beam rises over the wall, the chain runs down to the ship. On-screen label: RECONSTRUCTION.

Reconstruction Principle: Polybius 8.6.2. Machine design: ours



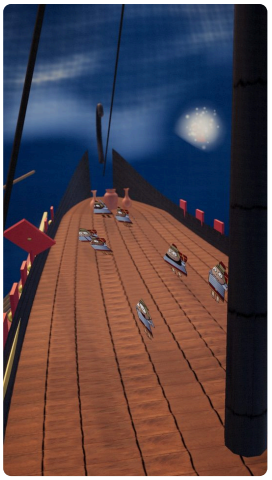
S10 0:25.9–0:28.0

The bow rises

VO ...and the front of the ship rises.

The bow and chain against the sky, oars dangling, water streaming.

Documented Polybius 8.6.3



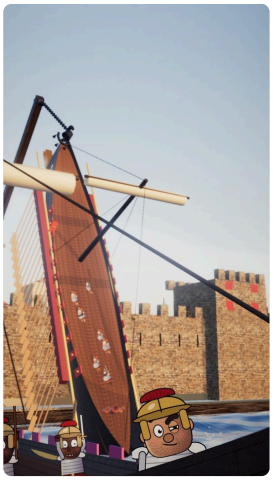
S11 0:28.0–0:29.4

Vertigo

VO Higher...

Looking down the tilting deck: the crew and cargo slide away. Shields and oars start to fall.

Dramatised Dramatisation



S12 0:29.4–0:31.6

Marcellus watches

VO ...until it's standing on its stern.

Marcellus aghast in the foreground, his ship standing upright behind him. Sunrise.

Documented Polybius 8.6.3



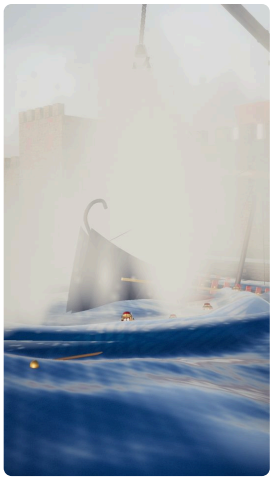
S13 0:31.6–0:33.0

Then they let go

VO Then... they let go.

Archimedes, sly grin, gives the signal. Pulley snap.

Documented Release: Polybius 8.6.3. Archimedes on the wall: dramatisation



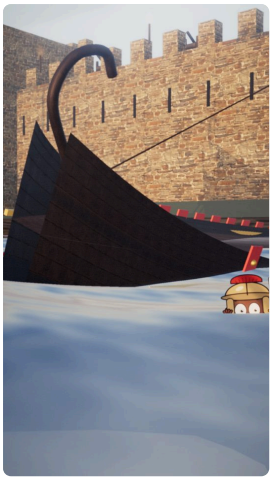
S14 0:33.0–0:36.0

The drop, in slow motion

VO (no narration)

Half-speed fall, then the impact: a tower of spray, a crater in the sea and a wave ring rolling outward. Silence, then the roar.

Documented Polybius 8.6.4



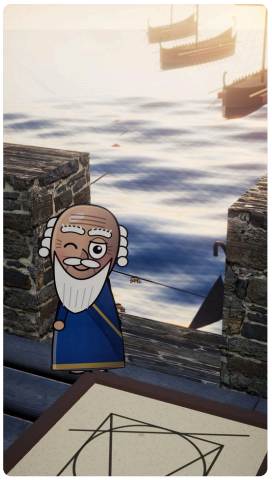
S15 0:36.0–0:37.5

Swamped

VO Some ships capsized. Most just filled with water.

Waterline view: the swamped hull, sailors bobbing, shields and oars floating.

Documented Polybius 8.6.4



S16 0:37.5–0:42.5

The mathematician

VO The genius behind it wasn't a general. He was a mathematician in his seventies: Archimedes.

Absorbed in his sand diagram, he looks up and winks at camera.

Documented Age: Tzetzes. Diagram: Plutarch 19. The wink: our acting



S17 0:42.5–0:46.5

Marcellus jokes

VO The Roman commander joked that Archimedes was using his ships to scoop up seawater...

Soaked Marcellus forces a laugh.

Documented Polybius 8.6.6; Plutarch 17.1



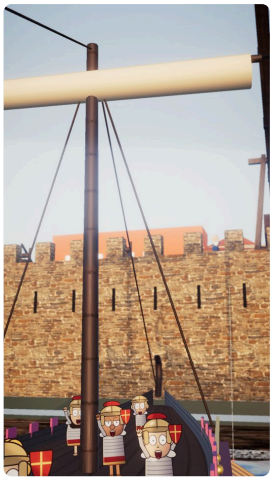
S18 0:46.5–0:49.5

Nobody laughs

VO ...his men didn't laugh.

Deadpan soldier. Water drips.

Dramatised Dramatisation



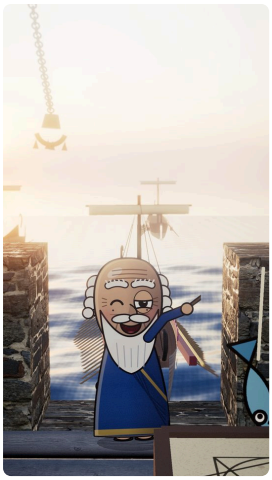
S19 0:49.5–0:53.5

Days later: 'There it is!'

VO One ancient writer says that whenever a rope or a stick poked over the wall, they screamed...

Titus, lip-synced: "THERE IT IS!" Shields up, one marine leaps overboard, oars back water.

Documented Plutarch, Marcellus 17.3. The leap: invented



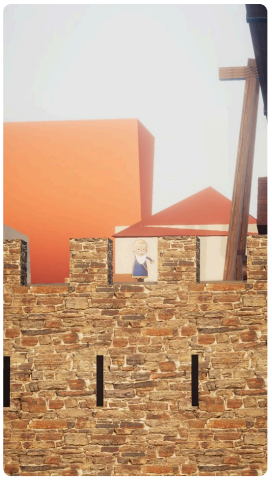
S20 0:53.5–0:55.5

It was a fishing rod

VO ...and fled.

Reverse angle: the dreaded stick is Archimedes' fishing rod. He lands a fish and winks as the fleet flees.

Invented Invented joke illustrating Plutarch 17.3



S21 0:55.5–1:02.0

Rome waits

VO Rome stopped attacking the walls. It just waited... because of one old man.

Telephoto from the fleet: the great wall, the claw at rest, and one tiny old man fishing in a gap in the battlements.

Documented Polybius 8.7.5–9; Plutarch 17.3

Narration script

0:00.0	This is a Roman warship...
0:01.9	...and a city wall is picking it up.
0:03.6	Rewind.
0:04.4	Syracuse, 213 BC. Before dawn, Rome's fleet creeps toward the city walls.
0:09.4	The plan: get so close that the city's catapults...
0:11.0	...shoot right over their heads. And it works.
0:13.9	Then, above them... something creaks.
0:16.4	A huge beam swings out over the wall... and lowers an iron hand on a chain.
0:20.4	It grabs the ship by the nose.
0:22.4	Behind the wall, the far end of the beam is pushed down, like a seesaw...
0:25.9	...and the front of the ship rises.
0:28.0	Higher...
0:29.4	...until it's standing on its stern.
0:31.6	Then... they let go.
0:36.0	Some ships capsized. Most just filled with water.
0:37.5	The genius behind it wasn't a general. He was a mathematician in his seventies: Archimedes.
0:42.5	The Roman commander joked that Archimedes was using his ships to scoop up seawater...
0:46.5	...his men didn't laugh.
0:49.5	One ancient writer says that whenever a rope or a stick poked over the wall, they screamed...
0:53.5	...and fled.
0:55.5	Rome stopped attacking the walls. It just waited... because of one old man.

Titus (on screen, lip-synced): "THERE IT IS!" in S19.

What the sources say

> "...when he had got hold of her by the prow, would press down the opposite end of the machine which was inside the wall. Then when he had thus by lifting up the ship's prow made her stand upright on her stern ... let the chain and hand suddenly drop." (Polybius 8.6)

> "...whenever they saw a bit of rope or a stick of timber projecting a little over the wall, 'There it is,' they cried ... and turned their backs and fled." (Plutarch, Marcellus 17)

> "...every hope of capturing the town at once if one old man of Syracuse were removed." (Polybius 8.7)

Labelled as not historical

- The fishing rod, the fish and the marine leaping overboard are comic inventions that illustrate Plutarch's line.
- The machine's dimensions, counterweight and windlass are our reconstruction.
- We stage Polybius's account (prow lifted, ship stood on its stern, then dropped), not Plutarch's mid-air whirling.
- The ship is stylised at 30 m. A real quinquereme was about 45 m.

Approvals needed

ITEM	TOOL	ESTIMATE
Narration, about 62 s, one voice	ElevenLabs via Higgsfield	≈ 5 credits
Character lines: "THERE IT IS!" plus a whisper	ElevenLabs via Higgsfield	≈ 1 credit
Original score, about 62 s	Music generation via Higgsfield	≈ 9 credits
3D render, captions, sound effects, mix	Our pipeline	free
Total		**≈ 15 credits (about $0.60)**

After you approve the visuals, I'll get the exact quote from Higgsfield and show it to you before generating anything.

Still to polish during production

- S14: the spray is bigger and taller but still a little foggy. I'll add sharper droplet sheets.
- S10 is an abstract low angle. If it doesn't cut well in the animatic, I'll swap it for a side angle.
- S19: the mast and yard crowd the frame. I'll add a quick close-up of Titus screaming.
- S21: the city buildings behind the wall are plain. I'll add doorways, windows and roof detail.
- Lip-sync will be checked frame by frame against the recorded narration and Titus's line.